distance himself and his country from Castro's actions, saying that "he had nothing to add to the previous Soviet position on overflights."[14]

On the next day, November 16, Khrushchev called another meeting of the Presidium to discuss the escalating situation in and around Cuba. Officially on the agenda was the Soviet response to Kennedy's latest demand to remove the bombers in exchange for lifting the blockade, but the focus of the discussion was on Castro, not Kennedy. Khrushchev and then Gromyko, as the main spokesman on international relations, were first to speak, followed by Leonid Brezhnev, Aleksei Kosygin, and Frol Kozlov—people responsible in the party and government for domestic matters and the economy. Then came the turn of the two ideologues, Mikhail Suslov and Boris Ponomarev. All three groups of state and party officials were in agreement: Castro's position was "unreasonable and screechy."

"Let this be a lesson to us," wrote the notetaker, recording words probably spoken by Khrushchev. "We are coming to the crunch point: either they will cooperate, or we will let our people go." The notion of a Soviet withdrawal from Cuba, regarded a few days earlier as a manifestation of Castro's immaturity, emotionality, and eccentricity, was now being entertained by the Soviet leadership as a legitimate option if Castro refused to go along with their policy. They no longer saw any room for maneuver. Discussing Mikoyan's request to allow him to meet once again with Castro, the Presidium decided to inform him that whatever the talks he engaged in, the decision on removing the bombers had not only been made but already delivered to the Americans.[15]

Khrushchev personally dictated the instructions to Mikoyan. He stated that the Cuban ultimatum to stop American overflights and start shooting at their planes could lead to war: "To act in such a manner now would lead to a military conflict, and it could develop if one would follow such a course, it could not be justified by anything and would have no grounds." Khrushchev instructed Mikoyan to present the Cubans with an ultimatum of a different sort. "If the Cuban comrades do not want to cooperate with us on this issue and do not want to undertake measures which would help us resolve this issue and avoid being pulled into a war together with us, then apparently the conclusion that we see is that our presence in Cuba is not